

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CHICAGO CITY COUNCIL

Vote affirms sanctuary city status

Conservatives had sought to allow police to work with feds to deport immigrants accused of crimes

By **Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan**
Chicago Tribune

An effort by opponents of Mayor Brandon Johnson to water down Chicago's sanctuary city ordinance faltered in the City Council Wednesday, a victory for the mayor

as his administration prepares for the looming threat of deportations under incoming President Donald Trump.

Aldermen voted 39-11 to table the vote on an amendment from Southwest Side Aldermen Raymond Lopez, 15th, and Silvana

Tabares, 23rd, to allow Chicago police to work with federal agencies on deportation cases with individuals accused or convicted of gang activity, drug-related crimes, sex trafficking or sex crimes with minors. The two used a parliamentary move to attempt to force a full vote in the council, but the Johnson administration's campaign with progressive allies and immigration advocates succeeded at

beating back the legislation.

The council's failure to amend the ordinance was no surprise; even if Lopez's proposal had passed, there would have been a 34-vote hurdle to clear a potential mayoral veto. But the council contingent of conservative and moderate aldermen are expected to continue resisting the freshman

Turn to Council, Page 4

CREDIT DOWNGRADE: Ratings agency S&P downgraded the city of Chicago's general obligation debt late Monday, citing structural imbalance in the just-passed 2025 budget, limited options for new revenue down the line and a lack of willingness among leadership to cut spending. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

A boon for bike, bus lane safety

Pilot program leads to 3,500 warnings, tickets in first weeks

By **Sarah Freishtat**
Chicago Tribune

The first weeks of a program to test automated ticketing of vehicles parked in bike and bus lanes downtown generated thousands of warnings and violations, data obtained by the Tribune show.

Between Nov. 6 and Dec. 13, the city issued some 3,577 warnings and tickets to parking scofflaws under the new Smart Streets pilot program. The vast majority were warnings, as only warnings could be issued during the first month of the program and even after that warnings are still issued for a first violation. But the city did issue 13 tickets in the first weeks of December, the data show, which would have been given for repeat violations.

Though the program is too new to draw conclusions, the number of warnings and tickets shows that drivers blocking bike or bus lanes is a persistent issue, said Jim Merrell, managing director of advocacy for the Active Transportation Alliance. The blockages make cycling less safe and buses less efficient, he said.

"It's obviously a problem that needs to be addressed," he said.

The program allows the city to use cameras to mail tickets to registered vehicle owners for violations in an area that covers much of downtown, running from the lake to Ashland Avenue on the west, North Avenue to the north and Roosevelt Road to the south. It is planned to run for two years.

It is set to ultimately include parking meter violations and an effort to prevent double parking in commercial loading zones, in addition to bike- and bus-lane violations. Parking

Turn to Tickets, Page 5



Palestinians celebrate the announcement of a ceasefire deal between Hamas and Israel in the Gaza Strip on Wednesday. **ABDEL KAREEM HANA/AP**

Sides reach temporary ceasefire deal in Gaza

But Netanyahu says final details of pact that would free hostages still in flux

By **Najib Jobain, Samy Magdy and Josef Federman**
Associated Press

DOHA, Qatar — Israel and Hamas agreed to pause the devastating war in the Gaza Strip, mediators announced Wednesday, raising the possibility of winding down the deadliest and most destructive fighting between the bitter enemies.

The three-phase ceasefire deal promises the release of dozens of hostages held by militants in Gaza and hundreds of Palestinian prisoners in Israel, and it will allow hundreds of thousands of people displaced in Gaza to return to what remains of their homes. It also will flood desperately needed humanitarian aid

into a territory ravaged by 15 months of war.

The prime minister of Qatar, Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani, said the ceasefire would go into effect Sunday and that its success would depend on Israel and Hamas "acting in good faith in order to ensure that this agreement does not collapse."

President Joe Biden touted the deal from Washington, saying the ceasefire will stay in place as long as Israel and Hamas remain at the negotiating table over a long-term truce.

Biden credited months of "dogged and painstaking American diplomacy" for landing the deal, while noting that his

Turn to Ceasefire, Page 9



Protesters call for the return of hostages in Tel Aviv, Israel, after a ceasefire deal was reached on Wednesday. A statement released by the White House said that the deal will "reunite the hostages with their families after more than 15 months in captivity." **AMIR LEVY/GETTY**



Allie, a pregnant 37-year-old bottlenose dolphin, is fed by Heather Downing, lead animal care specialist, at the Brookfield Zoo on Tuesday. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Brookfield Zoo ready for a water birth

Facility expecting its first bottlenose dolphin calf in a decade, along with a chance to learn from it

By **Adriana Pérez**
Chicago Tribune

This summer the Brookfield Zoo's bottlenose dolphin habitat will reverberate with the chatty whistles and playful leaps of a new calf — the first expected to be born there in over a decade. On Wednesday, the zoo announced the upcoming addition to its seven dolphins as 37-year-old Allie enters her second trimester of pregnancy. Almost 20% of dolphin calves

born to first-time mothers in the wild don't survive their first year. It's a crucial time full of challenging milestones, so Allie — already an experienced mother of four — and her new calf will offer the zoo's staff a chance to deepen its knowledge and contribute to the scientific understanding of prenatal and neonatal dolphin care.

"Our dolphins here at the zoo serve an incredibly important role in inspiring people and connecting them to wildlife and nature," said

Mike Adkesson, the zoo's president and CEO. "We're tremendously excited to be back in a position where we will be welcoming a new little one shortly."

Brookfield Zoo has a long history of dolphin care and research. In 1961, it opened the country's first inland dolphin aquarium. For over five decades, the zoo has also led the Sarasota Dolphin Research Program in Florida, the world's longest-running wild dolphin conservation program, which studies bottlenose dolphins as indicators of the overall health of the

Turn to Dolphin, Page 2

